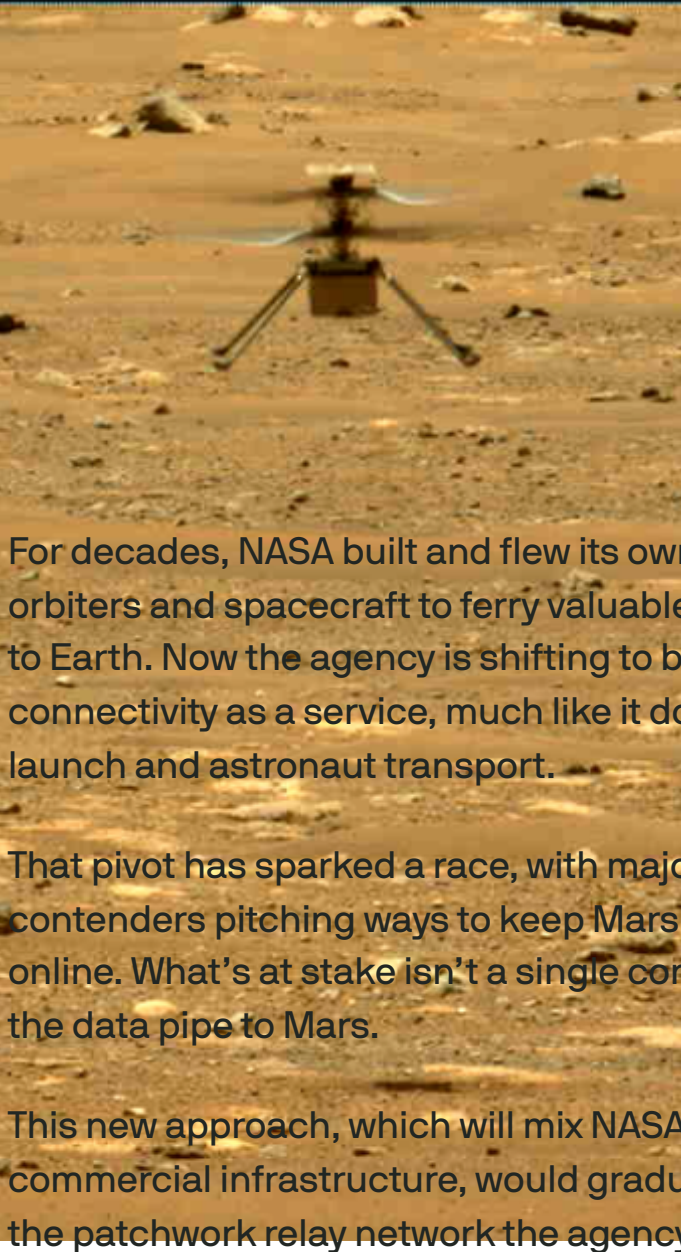


SPACE



**NASA has sparked a race
to develop the data
pipeline to Mars**



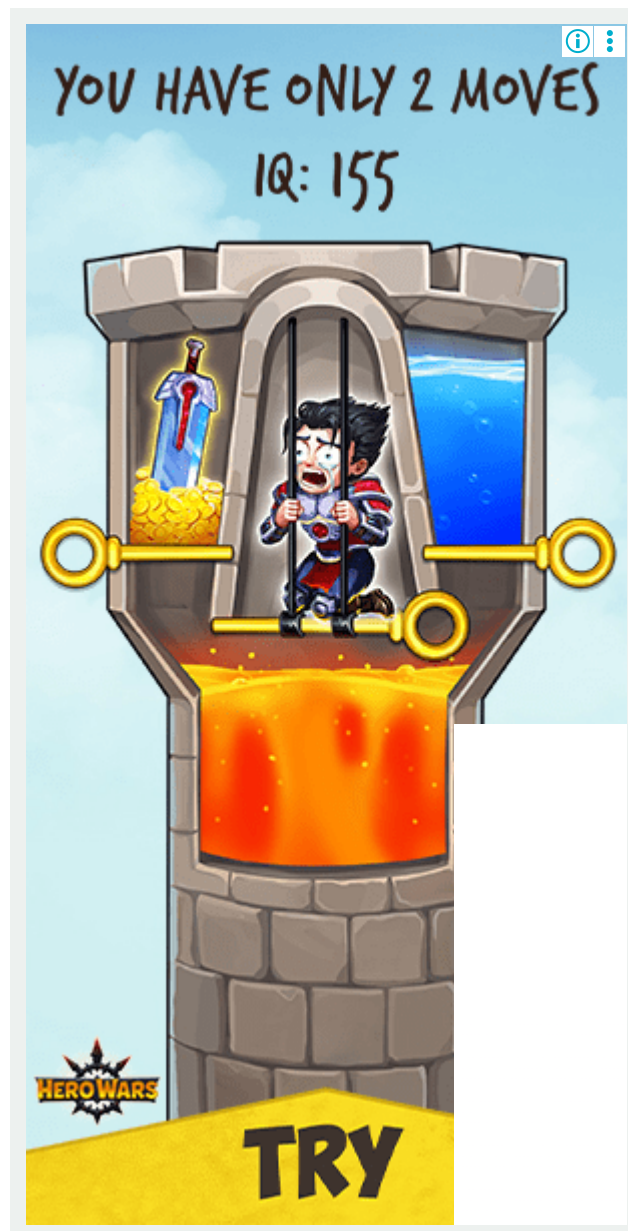
For decades, NASA built and flew its own relay orbiters and spacecraft to ferry valuable data back to Earth. Now the agency is shifting to buying connectivity as a service, much like it does for launch and astronaut transport.

That pivot has sparked a race, with major contenders pitching ways to keep Mars missions online. What's at stake isn't a single contract: it's the data pipe to Mars.

This new approach, which will mix NASA assets and commercial infrastructure, would gradually replace the patchwork relay network the agency relies on today. Generally, that works by orbiters like Mars Reconnaissance Orbiter and MAVEN that pick up data from rovers and landers and transmit it to the Deep Space Network's (DSN) giant antennas on Earth.

NASA's relay spacecraft are still healthy, but they were never meant to be a permanent backbone. The [agency's latest senior review](#) on planetary missions calls out MAVEN's critical role as a relay and provides steps to keep it available into the early 2030s. But eventually, this hardware will decay.

At the same time, NASA's Space Communications and Navigation (SCaN) program, which manages the DSN, is looking for solutions to augment these aging assets. The aim, according to an RFP released in July and due today, is to create an interoperable



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marketplace where NASA can be one of many customers instead of the owner-operator.

The current request is specifically for capability studies, not immediate hardware buys. The ask is twofold: a “lunar trunkline” between the moon and Earth and end-to-end Mars communications that move data from assets on the surface, through Mars orbit, and to operations centers on Earth.

It’s a formidable challenge. Any architecture must contend with the vast distance between Earth and the moon and Mars, long latency, periodic solar interference and Earth visibility windows, and high requirements for fault-tolerant systems. That’s why NASA is asking for plans, to gauge how industry might solve these puzzles, rather than immediately jumping to procurement.

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While TechCrunch can’t confirm which companies are submitting concept proposals, a handful have already staked their place in the race.

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Blue Origin [just unveiled](#) a Mars Telecommunications Orbiter built on its Blue Ring platform, pitched as maneuverable, high-performance spacecraft to support NASA missions to Mars as soon as 2028. Rocket Lab has touted its own Mars telecom orbiter concept, [which the company says](#) is a core element of its proposed architecture for the Mars Sample Return campaign.

In 2024, NASA’s Mars Exploration Program [separately funded 12 short commercial services studies](#), including a trio of studies for next-gen relay services, to SpaceX, Lockheed Martin, and Blue Origin. SpaceX’s proposal to “adapt Earth-orbit communication satellites for Mars” will likely be derived from its Starlink internet satellite constellation.

The long-term goal is to transform the agency’s planetary exploration agenda from pure-science missions to a permanent human presence on the moon and, eventually, on Mars.

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Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the public utilities...

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SECURITY



US spy chief says UK has dropped its Apple backdoor demand

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 7:25 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

The U.K has dropped its demand for special access to Apple’s cloud systems, or a “backdoor,” following negotiations with the Trump administration, according to U.S. National Intelligence Director Tulsi Gabbard.

“As a result, the U.K. has agreed to drop its mandate for Apple to provide a ‘back door’ that would have enabled access to the protected encrypted data of American citizens and encroached on our civil liberties,” [Gabbard wrote in a post on X](#). She also claimed that she worked along President Donald Trump and Vice President JD Vance in the negotiations.

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Over the past few months, I've been working closely with our partners in the UK, alongside [@POTUS](#) and [@VP](#), to ensure Americans' private data remains private and our Constitutional rights and civil liberties are protected.

As a result, the UK has agreed to drop its mandate for...

— DNI Tulsi Gabbard (@DNIGabbard) [August 19, 2025](#)

This is the latest (and unexpected) development in a months-long saga that saw the British government secretly demanding Apple grant its authorities access — essentially asking for a [backdoor](#) — to the encrypted data of iCloud users, effectively anywhere in the world, particularly those who turn on [Advanced Data Protection](#) (or ADP), an opt-in security feature. ADP [turns on end-to-end encryption](#) for iCloud, meaning only the user can access their files stored on Apple's cloud servers.

The existence of the legal demand was first reported by [The Washington Post](#) in February, which was made under the [U.K.'s Investigatory Powers Act 2016](#), also known as the Snoopers' Charter. The request [sparked outrage and condemnation](#) from privacy and security experts worldwide, who argued that if the U.K. government obtained what it wanted, it would weaken privacy for the whole world, and also open the door for more governments to make similar demands, even in other companies' technologies.

[Apple initially responded by removing ADP from the U.K.](#), meaning new users couldn't turn it on. The company also said it would give guidance to existing users who "will eventually need to disable this security feature."

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In the meantime, Apple also [reportedly challenged the backdoor mandate](#) in court, a case that was initially secret but [was then ruled to be held in public](#).

Apple and the U.K. Home Office, which initiated the demand on behalf of the British government, did not respond to requests for comment.

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Olivia Coleman, the press secretary of the U.S. Office of the Director of National Intelligence, referred to a February letter to Sen. Wyden and Rep. Biggs.

Apple previously told TechCrunch that the company has “never built a backdoor or master key” to any of its products or services and it “never will.”

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CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

[Keychain](#), a U.S. startup that [helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners](#), has raised \$30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

IMAGE CREDITS: KEYCHAIN

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team already represents half of Keychain's 70-person global headcount, with about 20 employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

The strategy is deliberate. Despite only serving Western markets, Keychain has built its primary

development operations in Gurugram — which is the country’s second-largest tech hub after Bengaluru — to develop its consumer packaged goods (CPG) platform for clients in North America. The software platform already helps eight of the top 10 retailers, including 7-Eleven and Whole Foods, and seven of the top CPG brands, such as General Mills, connect with potentially suitable manufacturers, according to the startup. So why India?

“It’s the talent, depth, availability, and the speed with which you can access talent of that depth and availability [in India],” said Oisin Hanrahan, co-founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi, has been a “natural advantage” in building Keychain’s core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.



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“We’ve thought about engineering as: how do we build a core, sustainable engineering organization that can get to scale reasonably quickly, that has endurance, that’s got deep talent pools, and AI exposure that can take on real, important challenges, that’s commercially minded? And we looked at where we had those teams before, when we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes,” Hanrahan told TechCrunch.



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Several U.S. startups, [especially those developing SaaS solutions](#), base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a [wave of multinational companies establishing offshore hubs](#), often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also

target Indian consumers even as many say [India is harder to sell into](#) — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK’s [Deliveroo](#) and Southeast Asia’s [Gojek](#) and [Grab](#) — all of which tap into India’s tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

“India’s position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country,” said Neha Singh, co-founder of the Bengaluru-based private market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India’s time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

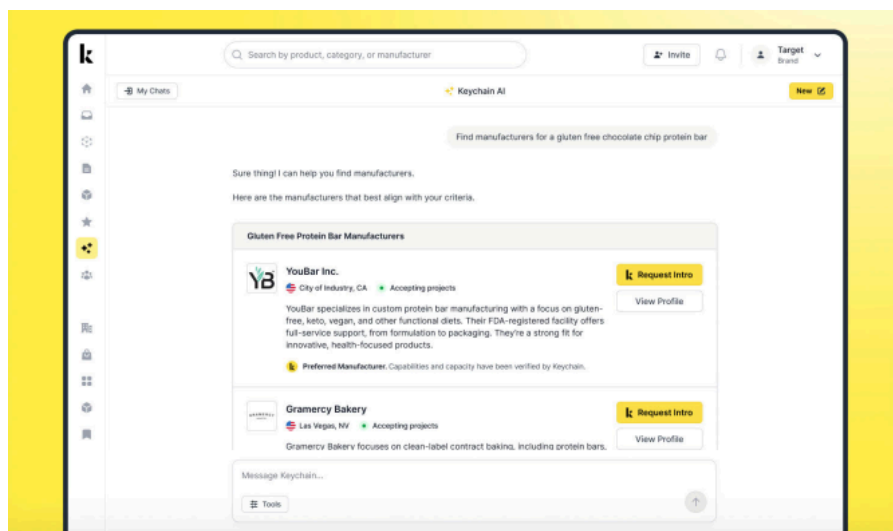
Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull data using natural language when an auditor

requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.



KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is [aiming to enter Europe](#) later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the

platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from \$10,000 to over \$100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around \$20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

Keychain’s Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised \$68 million in total. Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over \$50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of \$260 million in its last round of \$15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

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Jagmeet Singh

Reporter |

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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IMAGE CREDITS:
ARTUR WIDAK/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

APPS



TikTok's latest feature lets college students find and connect with classmates

Aisha Malik — 6:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

In a move reminiscent of Facebook's early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the "Add school" button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email

address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

Users can then browse their school's page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

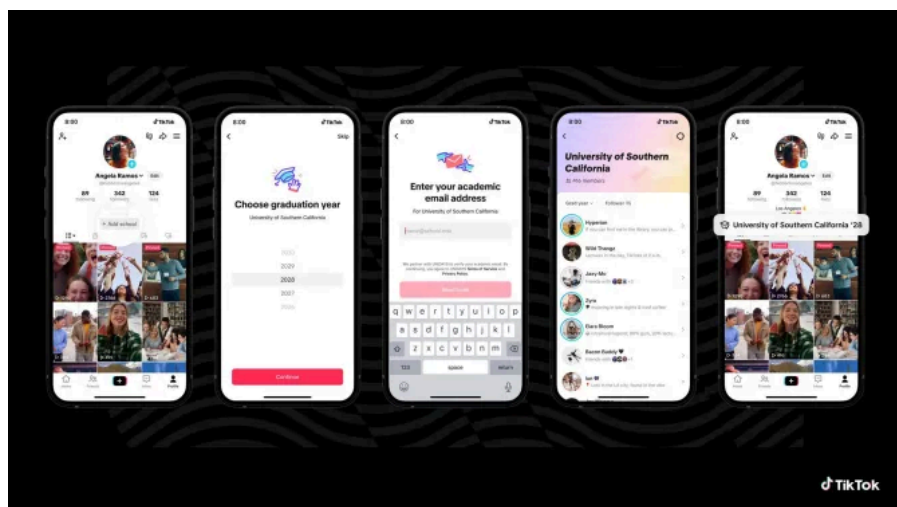


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok's partnership with [UNiDAYS](#), a student verification platform that confirms student status.

TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook's original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok's new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.



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It's worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was [spotted testing a similar feature](#) last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It's unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

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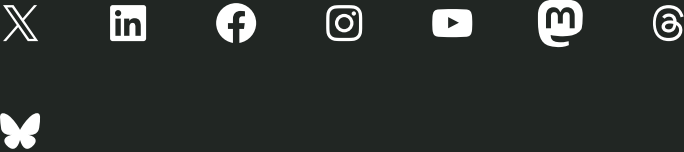
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Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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